directions. The powerful combination of political conservatism, epistemic limitations (related to knowledge about the Taliban), and the polarisation of regional political equations in the 1990s had hindered India from reaching out to the Taliban regime. By 2015, however, out of necessity if not want, Indian policymakers had begun making critical conceptual distinctions about the place of the Taliban in Afghanistan's sociopolitical landscape. The Taliban constituted a diverse and loosely held-together band of militants fighting Western forces and the Afghan government, and were not a monolithic entity. This view gained appreciation among Indian policymakers. Imbuing a complex set of grievances and ambitions, these insurgents had varying degrees of piety, and most of them were rooted in rural Pashtun cultures. To be clear, no Indian policymaker ever wants the Taliban to return. But the impossibility of militarily defeating such a heterogeneous group made it necessary for India to reconsider its policy. Thus, instead of being blindly opposed to the Taliban, New Delhi began viewing those political outfits and figures that were 'dependent' on Pakistan for political and financial sustenance as the problem entities.

The reason for this was the logic that dependence on Pakistan promised reduction in the sovereign agency of such groups in a way that may harm Indian interests. An important distinction here is India's acceptance of the fact that any Afghan government would be dependent on external financial and military support. The source of such support, however, should not be from Pakistan. For in that scenario, the Afghan government would be expected to do Pakistan's bidding in Afghanistan either willingly or by force. An important, if not the only or even the most critical aspect of Pakistan's Afghanistan policy was to reduce the Indian presence in that country (especially the four Indian consulates that Islamabad alleged were being used to forment violence and separatism within Pakistan). The IC-814 hijacking incident was a perfect example of an Afghan regime getting caught between India-Pakistan tensions against its wishes. Despite wanting to help India secure the lives of the hostages, the Taliban was unable to openly criticise Pakistan for using Afghan territory to execute the negotiations phase of the hijacking. The incident also underlined the costs that India had to bear by not engaging with the Taliban. The only difference in 2015 was the increasing degree of pragmatism wherein India began to distinguish between the